13.3 Look and feel

The web is an ever-changing place, and new tools pop up all the time, especially to make your site look more interesting. There are many third-party packages that integrate UI tool kits and other web goodness into Django. This section covers two tools and one technique. Django Grappelli is a drop-in replacement for the Django Admin, bringing pretty to your favorite administration tool. Crispy Forms is a series of libraries offering fine-grained control over form rendering with reusable components. Favicons are those funky little icons in your browser's tabs, and as they're a little messy; you'll need a couple of tricks to make it easier to serve them from Django.

13.3.1 Django Grappelli

One of the common complaints about the Django Admin is its lack of visual appeal. OK, let's be blunt: it's ugly. The Django Admin is only meant as a support tool. Its lack of aesthetic appeal isn't important, but you can do something about it. Django Grappelli (https://pypi.org/project/django-grappelli/) is a drop-in replacement for the Django Admin's templates.

You install Grappelli using `python -m pip install django-grappelli`. Note that if you're using an older version of Django (prior to to 4.0), you will need a different version of Grappelli. Check the docs for specific information. Once you've got it installed, add `"grappelli"` to `INSTALLED_APPS`, ensuring you put it before the line for `"django.contrib.admin"`. Grappelli has a few of its own views that need to be registered as routes: `path("grappelli/", include("grappelli.urls"))`, which also needs to be included before the admin routes. You also need to make sure the `context_processors` configuration in `TEMPLATES/OPTIONS` includes `django.template.context_processors.request`, which it does by default.

That's pretty much it; once configured, your Django Admin has a more modern look. It uses a grid based layout, changes the side panels into drop-down menus, and adds a cleaner header and footer. Figures 13.2 and 13.3 show you the difference between the default and Grappelli styling, so you can decide which appeals to you more.

13.3.2 Crispy forms

Let's face it, the look and feel of vanilla web forms is so yesterday—in fact, it's probably more like yesterday's yesterday. Most websites use frontend frameworks, such as Bootstrap and Tailwind to help with both layout and styling. Django's form tools are built around vanilla forms, and although you can add styling, it is a bunch of extra work. Django Crispy Forms (https://pypi.org/project/django-crispy-forms/) is a third-party library that helps you write reusable web forms.

Crispy Forms is broken into separate packages: the main package contains the form helper, while secondary template packs are for particular UI tool kit libraries. To install Crispy Forms, you need to run `python -m pip install django-crispy-forms` and register `"crispy_forms"` in `INSTALLED_APPS`. Then, depending on your choice of